

- ◇ 标蓝词汇为本学期要求记忆的词汇;
- ◇ 紫色词汇为六级以上词汇, 小测和期末词汇题不涉及;
- ◇ 红色词汇为完全超纲词汇。

Down with the mega-rich

The Economist

In January 2021 Marc Benioff, the billionaire founder of Salesforce, a software firm, delivered his **verdict**(=judgment) on the pandemic's first year. "We have to say it," he declared to those observing **the virtual proceedings**(the process online) of the World Economic Forum (WEF), an **annual**ⁱⁱⁱ gathering of the elite in Davos, Switzerland: "CEOs are **definitely**ⁱ the heroes of 2020."

- i. Definitely 来自 define, 定义。If we define a thing, we give it a very accurate, detailed and specific description. 所以, 定义即确定(某物的本质、性质、轮廓等), 所以副词的含义为 certainly, doubtlessly, undeniably, absolutely.
- ii. Annual means yearly;

The grandest of them were certainly among its winners. In that year, as millions of people died of covid-19 and many more faced **severe hardship**, the collective wealth of the world's billionaires rose by \$3.9trn, reports Peter Goodman, global economics correspondent(=journalist) for the *New York Times*, in his new book. The **incongruity**(=disharmony, the state of not being in a harmony 不和谐, 不协调) of the fortunes of the rich **soaring**(=rising) **amid**(=among) **mass suffering**(民间疾苦) is no accident, he **reckons**(=considers, thinks). Despite **fervent**(=zealous, keen) claims to the contrary by the mega-rich, Mr Goodman says, their pursuit of wealth has **undermined**(ruin, weaken, damage, destroy gradually 损害) society's capacity to deal with crises and left the world in its present troubled state.

Mr Goodman is a **veteran**(=experienced, senior) journalist who has covered economics for several papers and from postings around the globe. "Davos Man" is well-written and well-reported, and dedicated to(旨在) **exposing**(to disclose 揭露) the **falsity**(=falsehood, lie) of what he calls the "Cosmic Lie"—the notion that what helps the rich become richer benefits everyone. To **discredit**(to disbelieve, to cause sb not to believe in 使某物丧失信誉) it, Mr Goodman **juxtaposes**(=pair 并置) the view from the **luxury stomping grounds**ⁱⁱⁱ of the billionaire class with **vignettes**^{iv} from working-class neighbourhoods—pairing a yacht-riding(开游艇的) titan of fast fashion with a jobless textile worker, the spacefaring(坐飞船的) Jeff Bezos with an overworked Amazon package-picker.

iii. Stomping ground: a favorite or habitual resort 宜人而常去的景点

iv. Vignette: a small piece of writing, scene 一段小插曲。这句话, 作者的意思是, 将富豪阶级常踏足的奢华场所与工人阶级社区的一小片天地相对比。

He focuses on **a handful of** representative billionaires such as Mr Bezos and Stephen Schwarzman, the co-founder and ECO of Blackstone, a private-equity firm, towards whom the author appears to **harbour**(=embrace, have 抱有, 持有) a particular **animus**(=hatred, hostility 敌意). He serves up **juicy**(sensational, 言辞带煽动性的) quotes capturing Mr Schwarzman's **unrepentant glee**(无愧疚之意的喜悦) at the financial opportunities created by the pandemic ("There's always a way of making money in these types of **volatile**^{vi}

situations”). The author also documents the way some private-equity firms **piled into**^{vii} the health-care sector—and **slashed**^{viii} hospital capacity—in the years before the **advent**(coming, 来临) of covid-19.

v. A handful of, 一把, 即少量;

vi. Volatile: easily evaporated, changing rapidly and unpredictably 易变的, 不稳定的, volatile situations 在原文中可以翻译为“动荡的年月”;

vii. Pile into 是一个完全超纲词汇, 它是 pile 动词含义中的非常罕见的用法, 表示 flood, crowd into, 挤进;

viii. Slash: to reduce sharply, 原文指的是削减资金投入。

The text **vibrates**^{ix} with anger. The sense of outrage that **radiates**^x from the page is initially off-putting(=unpleasant), but becomes ever easier to share **over the course of**^{xiii} the book. It is **stoked**^{ix} not only, or even **primarily**(=mainly, principally), by the ways **the plutocrats** build their fortunes. Mr Goodman’s disgust is **spurred**^x more by gymnastic feats^{xi} of tax avoidance, the occasionally **staggering**(=surprising, 令人瞠目结舌的) lack of **empathy**(同理心, sympathy) and self-awareness, and the **towering**(extremely high, ultimate 极端的) injustice of extreme wealth alongside terrible **adversity**(=hardship, suffering). Thus the **spleen**^{xv} vented at the WEF, which in Mr Goodman’s description functions like billionaire **therapy**(=solution): a place where the very rich go to **reassure**(comfort 让某人心安理得) themselves that they are the solution to social **ills**(=evils, 其实就是 suffering, adversity, hardship) rather than the problem.

ix. Vibrate: to move, shake, shiver, waver rapidly to and fro 原意为震动, 颤抖;

x. 同学们都知道 radiation 表示辐射。Here, radiate means to spread, 散发出;

xi. Over the course of 是一个常见的高级表达, 它表示 during, along, 随着某物的逐渐展开。E.g. She has been a very dedicated scientist over the course of the past 15 years;

xii. Stoke means to stir up, fuel, 在原文中表示激怒, 点燃;

xiii. Spur means to stimulate, fuel, stoke, stir 表示激起, 与 stoke 近义;

xiv. Gymnastic feats 在体育里包括后空翻、筋斗、倒立和侧手翻等一系列体育杂技, 在文中表示富豪为了避税使用的一系列**独门绝活**;

xv. Spleen 是人体的脾脏, 与人的情绪有密切关联。所以, spleen 的延伸含义为怨气, 怒气; vent means to expel, discharge 发泄。

But the book is not altogether **persuasive**. Its arguments are **weakened** by a determination to **pin** most of the world’s ills **on**^{xvi} the mega-rich. **Private-equity barons**(商业巨亨) may be responsible for **turfing** longtime **tenants** out of properties in order to **flip** them and turn a profit^{xvii}, but not for the high cost of housing generally, which has far more to do with middle-class homeowners’ success in limiting dense development^{xviii}. Neither is immense wealth necessarily a product of **tax-dodging**(避税) and rent seeking(收租). Mr Bezos, for example, would not be a billionaire if millions of consumers were not so **keen**(zealous) to shop with Amazon.

xvi. Pin sth on sb means to put the blame or responsibility on sth.将指责或责备归咎到某人身上;

xvii. 在这个句子里, flip 是一个罕见用法, 它表示 to renovate, 翻新, 翻修; turf means to drive sb out of, 赶出去。这个句子可以转译为: The billionaires may be to blame for driving the tenants(长租户) out of the houses so that they can renovate the houses and rent them again for higher profit.(就是“炒房”)

xviii. 这个句子的句末用了衔接方法的 Ellipsis(省略). 补齐以后是: middle-class homeowners' success in limiting dense development **of housing**. 作者认为, 高房价大部分是由于中产阶级利用自己的优势控制了房地产的密集建设, 从而减少可出租或可售卖的房产, 让房子供不应求, 价格增高。

Indeed, “Davos Man” itself shows that there is plenty of blame to go around. Mr Goodman documents(=record, register 记录) how **xenophobia**(排外心理) and **racism** flourish(=thrive, 滋生) in places left behind by economic change, and how the **charges**(=blames) often levelled(=aim, direct) at **refugees**(难民) and immigrants—that they are troublesome **freeloaders**(寄生虫)—are **baseless** (=groundless, 无依据的, 无理由的). But he sees **nativism**(本土主义) as another **black mark**(stain 污点) against billionaires, rather than an ethical failure by people who may have suffered, but have not lost their capacity for moral reasoning.^{xix} Similarly, he quotes a cab driver from Sunderland, in northern England, who **admits of**(=approve of) Brexit: “No one here really understood [it]...We just knew that people in London had been fucking us for as long as we could remember...It was our chance to fuck them back.”^{xx}

xix. The sentence can be interpreted as

“British people have their own fault to blame: though they are able to reason, they lack morality. So Peter Goodman’s belief that nativism is an evil of the billionaires is thus not completely correct or persuasive.” 也就是说, 作者认为英国部分地区的落后其实不完全是商业巨头们造成的, 而更应该归咎于英国本土人的道德缺失。他们明明可以理性地思考, 结果选择了“损人不利己”的做法——胡乱地投了“英国脱欧”那一票。

xx. 最后一句, 作者利用 Conjunctive devices(连接词)——Similarly——进行并列, 以说明 Mr. Goodman 只是直观地看那位计程车司机的话(We just knew that people in London had been fucking us = We just knew that those billionaires had been taking advantage of us 我们就只知道那帮家伙一直在剥削我们), 而这个司机的话语很明显夹杂着挖苦、讽刺、怨愤, 他投“英国脱欧”的那一票也很明显是出于报复心理: “我看英国脱欧了, 你们这帮富豪们到哪儿去挖金子去!”从这位计程车司机的心理我们可以看出来, 表面上, 他们将自己所处的困境归咎于富贵权势的身上, 而实质上是源于自己非理性的思考与道德的缺失, 投了英国脱欧那一票, 才让自己进一步陷于水深火热之中。

The **reckless**(careless, irresponsible 不计后果的, 不负责任的) use of individuals’ civic rights, as much as the sins of the billionaires, has **landed** some countries **in dire**(desperately urgent 危及的) straits(=situations, conditions). Mr Goodman ends by arguing that a better world is possible through the “thoughtful use” of democracy. It is, but only if voters are more interested in taking responsibility for improving their lot(=fortune, fate) than in searching for scapegoats(替罪羊).^{xxi}

xxi. 所以, 本文章的作者认为造成今天的局面, 有两种原因: 1, 以报复为目的的个人投票权益的滥用, 与 2, 亿万富翁家财万贯里固有的罪恶, 这两点共同塑造了如今悲惨的英国。最后一句话作者说 It is (Ellipsis 省略。完整的句子为: It is possible through the “thoughtful use” of democracy), but only if **voters**(=people like that cab driver) are more interested in taking responsibility for improving their fate than in searching for **scapegoats**(=the very rich, the billionaires, the baron, the plutocrats...). 也就是说, 只有等

到英国人能理性思考了，也愿意为自己的行为负责，而不是将困境都归咎于替罪羊们——refugees, immigrants and billionaires，才能成就一个 better world。作者的语气是什么样的，同学们能判断出来吗？作者用了 *only if*...这个前提表达，同时用了 *than in searching for scapegoats* 这一贬义词，说明作者对于能否达到 better world 这种目标是抱有一定消极态度的，对那帮滥用公民权益的英国人抱有批判的态度。